Homonymy of Pronouns in Slovene and Croatian

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In this talk, we address the problem of pronoun homonymy in Slovene and Croatian. Both languages exhibit three functionally distinct types of *wh*-pronouns that show considerable formal overlap: interrogative, relative, and indefinite pronouns.

In the first part of the talk, we examine multiple *wh*-constructions containing two or more *wh*-pronouns, at least one of which functions as an interrogative or relative pronoun. We show that such constructions occur in interrogative and relative clauses, as well as in autonomous multiple *wh*-constructions, which we argue developed from relative clauses.

Our point of departure is that the functional status of pronouns in multiple *wh*-constructions is not always straightforward, especially when semantic interpretation alone does not clearly distinguish one pronoun type from another. This issue is particularly relevant for multiple *wh*-constructions corresponding to multiple partitive constructions (Haspelmath 1997: 177–179), which occur either as answers to questions containing multiple *wh*-constructions or as a concretisation of the content of a relative clause.

To resolve this issue, we draw on formal, semantic, and syntactic evidence and argue that, in the constructions under investigation, only the first pronoun has interrogative or relative status, while the remaining pronouns function as bare indefinites.

The second part of the presentation focuses on compound pronouns consisting of a *wh*-stem and an additional element. While Croatian features a series of pronouns ending in *-god*, Slovene employs those in *-koli*. We demonstrate that these formally near-identical expressions correspond to two functionally distinct pronoun categories: indefinites and relatives. Specifically, we show that the Croatian *-god* series functions both as two types of indefinite pronouns—differentiated by accentuation and orthography (e.g., *tkògod* vs. *tko gȍd*)—and as a relative pronoun (*tko gȍd*). Semantically, the Croatian indefinite *tkògod* displays a paucal-potential reading, whereas *tko gȍd* exhibits a free-choice meaning, aligning with its homonymic relative counterpart. In contrast, both the indefinite and relative Slovene *-koli* constructions are uniformly associated with free-choice semantics.

In both languages, compound relative pronouns can introduce two types of clauses: relative clauses and a subtype of non-relative clauses that belongs to a broader class of clauses which is named in the literature in various ways: *unconditionals*, *concessive conditionals*, and *conditional concessive clauses*.

The variety of names for these constructions is related to their elusive semantics. At the end of the presentation, we offer our proposal for describing the meanings of these clauses and suggest some terminological solutions.